RESEARCH

Weighted Grades: What Other Districts Do

Research from the SPASD weighted grades student work group · 2026

SPASD uses an unweighted 4.0 GPA, where an A counts the same in every class. The district's weighted grades work group is looking at how nearby Wisconsin districts handle it.

District	What gets weighted	How
Wauwatosa	AP courses and UW–Green Bay dual credit	5.0 scale. Chosen because they're open to all students, taught by district teachers, overseen by outside groups, and earn college credit. Not retroactive.
Elmbrook	AP, level 5 world language, select advanced classes, Early College Credit, Start College Now	Small bonus added to a 4.0 scale per semester. No official class rank.
Middleton	AP courses only	5.0 scale. Chose the smallest change possible, open to adding more after 1–2 years of data.

Where SPASD's group stands

- Agreed on a 5.0 scale for weighted courses instead of bonus points
- Writing criteria for which courses qualify instead of naming classes one by one (draft below)
- Surveyed staff and is surveying caregivers in English and Spanish
- Also researching Verona and Oregon
- Goal: a framework to the Board by the end of November 2026

Recommendation (drafted Oct. 15, confirmed Oct. 20, 2026)

The criteria team started from one idea: weighted grades should recognize course rigor, reflecting challenge, effort, talent, and the number of prerequisites. Its draft recommends a 5.0 scale for:

- Capstone classes, including try-out based music courses (repeatable)
- AP courses
- Classes that earn industry certification or college credit, except classes equivalent to courses or elective credit already offered at the high school, and courses that don't transfer to UW colleges and universities for credit

Why the exceptions: some Madison College classes, like Start College Now or PE taken for a graduation requirement, only count at Madison College or match the high school's own classes. A class that transfers to UW schools still counts, like Calculus 2.

Rollout (agreed October 20, 2026)

Students in the work group agreed weighted grades should start with incoming freshmen in 2027–28 (the Class of 2031) and roll up, since current students already chose classes under the old rules. Next: a Board committee preview on Nov. 2, the full Board on Nov. 9, and a final vote at the end of November. This is the work group's recommendation; the Board decides.

Open questions

- Should weighting apply to current students or only incoming freshmen?
- Could weighting push students toward AP over classes they actually want to take?
- Will the district bring back a valedictorian system?

Independent and student-led. Written by Zackary Mark, a high school student in the Sun Prairie Area School District. Not an official SPASD document and does not speak for the district, its staff, or its Board. Shared in good faith; not meant to accuse any person. Contact: zackarymark160@gmail.com · Instagram @spasdstudentvoice